

Hsien

Far from the courts of the Kithain, far from the Dreaming and the chimerical wonders they devote themselves to, mortals dream other dreams. They dream not of knights and dukes, of courtly love and chivalrous battle, but of shapechanging raccoon dogs, of playful cats who know more than they let on, of monkey kings who topple even the pillars of Heaven. They dream of the small gods of the 10,000 Things — but those small gods dream only of walking the path between Heaven and Earth once more.

History

Once, the world was one with the August Personage of Jade, a sacred unitary perfection. That Age of Perfection was only slightly marred when the August Personage bade the world to divide, to become many, and the world beheld itself, and called itself beautiful. This Age of Beauty ended when small errors in the August Personage's design grew ever larger, breaking away from the divine will of Heaven. Thus the Yama Kings were born, and to contain their wickedness the August Personage of Jade elevated the Wan Xian, the 10,000 Immortals, and set them to watch over humanity. To safeguard the natural world similarly, the *Hsien*, or Shinma, were created — little gods to serve as Heaven's representatives on Earth, to respond to the prayers of trees, rocks, and water even as they did the prayers of mortals. This was the Age of Legends, and though it was not perfect, it was immeasurably grand.

But that seed of imperfection grew further, and the Yama Kings corrupted even the Wan Xian and sowed the seeds of dissent among the Shinma, who turned against one another. Furious that his bureaucracy had been turned against itself, the August Personage of Jade cast out the Shinma, cutting off the road between Heaven and Earth. Exiled forever on Earth, they endured an Age of Beautiful Sadness — which, in its turn, came to an end, as corruption and darkness waxed across the land.

We live now in the Age of Tribulation, an age of darkness and madness, the 11th hour before the coming Sixth Age. What, then, will become of the Shinma? Will the Sixth Age be an Age of Joy, wherein, if their souls are just and enlightened, they will be granted admittance to Heaven once more? Or will it be an Age of Sorrows, an age of hope extinguished, as the Shinma are left to rot with a dying world, and this Age the last chance for salvation? The Hsien cannot know, though many profess to — only the August Personage of Jade knows what is to come.

Shinma in the Fifth Age

The Hsien once walked proudly, their forms a mark of their divine parentage and authority. Now, cast out by the will of the August Personage of Jade, they have no recourse but to seek what shelter they can find, lest their enemies hunt them down for the pure Chi that makes up their bodies. For safety's sake, each Hsien undergoes the *kun shou* ritual, seeking out a mortal soul on the verge of death and quietly taking its place within the flesh, gaining protection against those who would

Glossary

The Hsien use many otherwise unfamiliar terms. Some, such as *Yugen*, are obvious analogues to Glamour. Others are less obvious.

- ⑤ **Hirayanu:** Shinma commoners, who take the shape of animals.
- ⑤ **Hotei form:** The human mask the Hsien use to hide their true nature, equivalent to a mortal seeming.
- ⑤ **Hsien-tsu:** Shinma who occupy the body of a dying child, and so are raised as human, with all the ties and obligations this provides for them. They are generally unaware of their true nature until adulthood.
- ⑤ **Hsien-jin:** Shinma who occupy the body of a dying adult, and who are fully aware of their nature from the moment of reincarnation.
- ⑤ **I Chih:** A discrete expression of Hsien elemental alchemy, *Wu Tan*.
- ⑤ **Kamuii:** Shinma nobility, whose nature aligns with one of the five elements (wood, fire, earth, metal, and water).
- ⑤ **Kun Shou:** The process of reincarnation Shinma use to occupy the body of a dying person, placing themselves where the mortal's departing soul once rested.
- ⑤ **Kwannon-jin:** One of the various kinds of Shinma, equivalent to kith.
- ⑤ **Shen:** A supernatural creature, including Shinma themselves as well as *Kuei-jin*, *hengeyokai*, and other inhabitants of the World of Darkness.
- ⑤ **Wani Form:** A Hsien's true appearance, which varies depending upon their *Kwannon-jin*.

hunt her down. In the process, however, she loses much of her memory — a harsh price indeed, for the Hsien hope to attain enlightenment through contemplation of the 10,000 Things, and each life lost and regained means they must start anew along that path.

Where the Shinma once served a single court, that of Heaven, they now must make courts of their own, for Heaven is often silent. As in mortal politics, misunderstandings and disagreements are rife, and court may struggle against court for 1,000 reasons. For the Hsien, a court is a refuge, a fraternal organization, a teacher, and a judge all in one. Each court has its own code of behavior, which is enforced internally (not that such enforcement is perfect). Of course, little stops other courts from meting out "justice" to nonmembers, save the prospect of raising the ire of another court, and even this not always sufficient reason to stay their hand. As a result, most Hsien belong to courts, and even if they only pay lip service to the ideals and goals of that court, it's much safer than being